STATE SCAN

GUJARAT: A UCC TEST RUN *PG 16*

KARNATAKA: BENGALURU TRAFFIC NO MORE? *PG 18*

▶ MAHARASHTRA

ALL PREY AT HIS FEET

The bizarre case of a multiple rape accused godman, Kharat Baba, stirs up Maharashtra

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**



SHELTERED FROM BLAME Ashok Kharat with Rupali Chakankar (middle), who quit as NCP women's wing president after their ties were revealed

IN ONE SECTOR, INDIA SHOWS EQUAL indices: godmen with a fetish for 'faith rape', or coercive sex under the hypnotic veil of religion. Maharashtra's latest exhibit, Ashok Kumar Eknath Kharat, may pass for a tax official but is, in fact, a shamanic predator with a bagful of voodoo tricks. Using superstition, or props like fake remote-controlled snakes, he collected a long ledger of victims, a hotline to VIP clients and enough skeletons in his cupboard to spook political parties.

His March 17 arrest has opened a can of worms—for both the political links and the lurid nature of the case itself, involving even the law against human sacrifice and black magic. The door to that hell was benign: Kharat's public-facing 'services' included help concerning jobs or basic life issues.

The victim whose complaint led to the arrest was typical. Marriage guidance led to a miasmic prison of serial rape: he victimised her for three years since 2022, claiming divine powers, warning that her husband would die or her marriage break if she resisted.

The self-styled 'Captain Kharat' had already called attention to himself in December, filing a police complaint on an extortion bid on him by people claiming possession of explicit videos. His office boy, Neeraj Jadhav, had installed spycams in his Canada Corner office in Nashik after a woman acquaintance, who was pregnant, told him about her ordeal at Kharat's hands. In February, at Kharat's behest, a decoy woman complainant sought to put police on Jadhav's trail. "But we realised Kharat was in the wrong, and collected evidence," says a police officer.

A SORCERER'S TOOLKIT

A witness came forth with 35 videos involving Kharat and eight women. Case nailed, the police got a bar on Kharat fleeing the country and formed an SIT. After his arrest, victim testimonies flowed. He had exotic accessories: besides remote-controlled snakes, he is also alleged to have collected fox's ears, tiger skins, polished tamarind seeds and other fake sparklers peddled as 'energised' gems. Allegations of sorcery, too, are being aired.